

WORD STUDY

Justification

What Does It Mean to Be Right?

An Etymological and Lexicographical Baseline

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Scripture quotations are from the King James Version.

Ask what *justification* means, and many Protestants will answer, “It means that God declares the sinner righteous.”¹ Others, particularly within the Roman Catholic tradition, have understood it to mean that God makes the sinner righteous.² The familiar debate therefore asks whether justification declares righteousness or produces righteousness.

But both answers begin one step too late.

Before asking whether God declares or makes someone righteous, we must ask what *righteous* means. Beneath *righteous* lies the more basic word *right*. What does it mean for someone or something to be right?

If *right* remains undefined, then “declare righteous” merely replaces one unexplained expression with another. It tells us what God says about the sinner without telling us what His judgment means. Likewise, “make righteous” tells us that something changes without identifying the nature of the change.

A sound understanding of justification must therefore begin beneath the theological controversy. It must begin with rightness itself.

What Does “Right” Mean?

Rightness is not an isolated substance or quality that something possesses by itself. It describes a relationship.

A measurement is right in relation to an established measure. A judgment is right in relation to the facts and the governing standard. A person stands right when he occupies the position that properly belongs to him within a legitimate order.

Rightness has a spatial and relational structure. It concerns where something stands in relation to what governs it.

This sentence is completely correct: all the words are spelled properly, the grammar, punctuation and syntax are standard; the font, type size and word spacing match the rest of the document; but it is not *right* because it is justified to the wrong margin.

¹Westminster Confession of Faith 11.1: God justifies “not by infusing righteousness,” but by pardoning sins and “accounting and accepting” persons as righteous for Christ’s sake.

²Council of Trent, Session VI, chapter 7: justification is “not remission of sins merely,” but also sanctification and inward renewal whereby an unjust person becomes just.

In every case, rightness is a standard-relative relation: it names the correspondence between a subject and whatever truly determines how that subject ought to stand. The subject and governing standard may differ—a sentence and the facts, a measurement and its measure, a line of text and its margin, or a person and a rightful authority—but the underlying structure remains the same.

The same spatial-relational structure appears whenever we speak of something corresponding to a standard, according with an order, conforming to a pattern, standing approved, falling short, crossing a boundary, or being brought into line. Such expressions are not merely decorative pictures placed around an otherwise abstract idea. They describe the common structure of rightness: a subject, that which governs its proper position, and the relation between them.

But identifying this common structure raises another question. What makes the governing standard legitimate? A person may correspond perfectly to an asserted standard and still remain wrong if that standard proceeds from an authority with no right to establish it.

Imagine a rebel who rejects a rightful king and establishes a rival government. The rebel may reproduce nearly all the king's laws. He may forbid murder and theft, require honesty, protect families, punish violence, and reward public service. His order may closely resemble the legitimate order. A person may conform completely to the rebel's commands and be regarded as an exemplary citizen within the rebel regime.

Nevertheless, the entire system remains out of alignment. The correct rebel remains worthy of death.

Its defect is not necessarily found in the individual commands. Its defect lies in their source. The rebel possesses no rightful authority to establish an independent order. His government is therefore illegitimate even where it imitates the legitimate government almost perfectly.

The rebel analogy exposes an important distinction. There may be two asserted standards, but only one real standard. The rebel standard may exercise power, command allegiance, and produce genuine behavioral conformity. What it cannot produce is true rightness, because it is independently sourced in an authority that has no right to rule.

Paul describes precisely this condition in Israel:

“For I bear them record that they have a zeal of God, but not according to knowledge. For they being ignorant of God's righteousness, and going about to establish their own righteousness, have not submitted themselves unto the righteousness of God” (Romans 10:2–3).

Their error was not simply that they lacked moral seriousness or possessed no knowledge of God's commands. They sought to establish righteousness while refusing submission to the One from whom righteousness proceeds. Their standard could closely resemble God's standard while remaining fundamentally misaligned because it had become *their own*—established and pursued independently of His authority. Rightness, then, cannot be reduced to outward correspondence with a set of rules; it includes proper relation to the rightful source of the standard.

A person may perform the correct action for the wrong authority. He may imitate the conduct of a loyal subject while remaining committed to the rebel order. His behavior corresponds materially to the king's command, but he himself remains relationally misaligned. He does what the king requires without standing beneath the king's authority.

The rebel order is parasitic. It borrows the shape of rightness while rejecting the authority from which rightness proceeds. Its imitation may be extremely convincing, but no degree of imitation can repair its fundamental misalignment.

Righteousness, then, must include more than moral performance. It includes proper placement within the order established by rightful authority. Its essential questions are not merely, "What did this person do?" and "Did his conduct correspond to the rule?" We must also ask, "Under whose authority does he stand? From what source does his obedience proceed? To what order does he belong?"

Applied to God, the standard of righteousness is not an arbitrary collection of rules imposed by superior power. Nor is it an independent moral law standing above God and judging Him. The true standard proceeds from God because He is the rightful Creator and Lord. His order is legitimate because all things properly belong under His authority.

Sin is consequently more than imperfect conformity to a moral code. It is existence organized under a rival authority. The sinner may imitate many features of God's order. He may act morally, honor social obligations, and display qualities resembling genuine righteousness. Yet he remains out of alignment because his life is sourced in self-rule rather than rightful submission to God. True righteousness is not merely doing what is right; it is standing where one rightfully belongs, under the authority of the One who has the right to rule.

We can now approach justification from a clearer baseline. If righteousness describes proper placement within a legitimate order, then to justify someone cannot fundamentally mean to transform his moral character. It must concern how that person stands in relation to the rightful standard and its source.

The question carried by justification is not first, "What qualities have been produced within this person?" It is:

Where does this person stand in relation to the rightful authority and the order that proceeds from Him?

Before bringing that question to the New Testament Greek, we should notice what the history of the English words already contributes.

The English Words: “Rightwise” and “Justify”

The English vocabulary of righteousness and justification brings together two different linguistic histories.

The words **right**, **righteous**, and **righteousness** belong to the native English stream. **Just**, **justify**, and **justification** entered English through French and Latin. The two families overlap in meaning, but they did not travel the same path.

The older form of *righteous* was **rightwise**. It comes from the Old English *rihtwīs*: *riht*, meaning “right,” joined with *wīs*, meaning a manner, state, or condition.³ The word described someone characterized by a right manner or condition.

The spelling eventually changed because English speakers associated the ending with words such as *gracious* and *bounteous*. The word *righteous* can therefore look as though it ends in the ordinary suffix *-ous*, but historically its structure is closer to **right-wise**.

The history of *rightwise* returns us to the question with which our study began: righteousness concerns the manner or condition in which someone stands as right.

The English word *right* has an even older spatial background. It is related to words associated with straightness, direction, ruling, and bringing something into its proper position. The English verb still preserves this sense. To *right* an overturned boat is to return it to its proper position. To *right* a wrong is to correct a condition that has departed from what ought to be.⁴

Etymology alone does not determine the meaning of righteousness; words must be interpreted according to their actual use. Nevertheless, the history is significant. English speakers did not have to invent spatial language to explain rightness. The concepts of straightness, direction, rule, and proper position were already present within the word-family.

The English word *justify* arrived by another route. Middle English received *justifien* through Anglo-French

³Oxford Advanced Learner's Dictionary, s.v. “righteous”; Merriam-Webster, s.v. “righteousness.” Righteous derives from Old English *rihtwīs*, formed from *riht* (“right”) and *wīs* (“manner, state, or condition”).

⁴Oxford Advanced Learner's Dictionary and Merriam-Webster, s.v. “right.” English *right* derives from Old English *riht* and belongs to an older family associated with straightness, direction, and rule.

justifier and Late Latin *iustificare*. The *Oxford English Dictionary* finds the word in English before 1382, in the early Wycliffite Bible.⁵

The Latin word is built upon *iustus*, “just,” with a verbal formation historically related to *facere*, “to do” or “make.” Its form therefore naturally permitted the sense “to make just.” This morphological appearance contributed to the historic understanding of justification as an inward making-righteous.

But the Latin form never restricted the word to moral transformation. Latin and the languages descended from it also used the verb for acting justly toward someone, administering justice, treating someone as just, declaring someone just, and demonstrating that someone or something was right. Early French usage included declaring a person just or recognizing him as innocent.⁶

The biblical translation history itself prevents us from allowing the Latin form to settle the question. The Latin Bible could say that people “justified God” in Luke 7:29. Whatever *iustificare* looked like morphologically, those people did not make God morally righteous. The Latin verb, like the Greek verb it translated, could describe the recognition of a subject as right.

English inherited the same breadth. In ordinary modern usage, to *justify* an action is to show that it accords with an adequate reason or standard. To justify oneself is to defend one’s standing. Evidence may justify a conclusion by demonstrating that the conclusion is warranted. A court may justify or vindicate a person by determining that his claim stands in the right.

English also developed a specialized typographical sense. To justify a line of text is to arrange it so that it aligns with a governing margin.⁷ This is the sense visually illustrated earlier: a sentence may be correct in its spelling, grammar, punctuation, syntax, font, and spacing while remaining wrongly justified because it stands against the wrong margin.

The typographical use is later, and we should not claim that New Testament writers used δικαιώω for the arrangement of written lines. The illustration is not, however, disconnected from the ancient word-family. Classical writers used δίκαιος of things that were even, balanced, properly proportioned, or exact: an even-going chariot, balanced opposing forces, and a measurement corresponding precisely to its stated length. The ancient vocabulary therefore could describe physical and quantitative alignment as δίκαιος, while δικαιώω could broadly mean “to set right.”⁸

⁵Oxford English Dictionary, s.v. “justify,” doi:10.1093/OED/5897928690; Merriam-Webster, s.v. “justify.” The OED’s earliest English evidence occurs before 1382 in the Wycliffite Bible.

⁶Centre National de Ressources Textuelles et Lexicales, s.v. “justifier”; Lewis and Short, A Latin Dictionary, s.v. “iustificatio.” Early French usage includes declaring someone just or recognizing someone as innocent.

⁷Merriam-Webster, s.v. “justify,” sense 3: to arrange lines of text so that they come out even at the margin.

⁸Liddell-Scott-Jones Greek-English Lexicon (LSJ), s.vv. “δίκαιος” and “δικαιώω.” LSJ records δίκαιος as equal, even, or well-balanced and gives “to set right” as the broad heading for δικαιώω.

The right-margin illustration does not prove the meaning of δικαιώ in any particular New Testament passage. It makes visible a relational structure already present within the ancient word-family: a subject stands right when it corresponds appropriately to its governing measure or boundary.

Taken together, the two English word-families approach the same conceptual territory from different directions:

- **Righteous** developed from *rightwise*: being characterized by a right manner or condition.
- **Justify** came through the Latin and French language of justice, right treatment, demonstration, judgment, and making or recognizing as just.
- **Typographical justification** makes the relational structure visible by aligning text to a governing margin—a modern application that closely resembles ancient uses of the δικ- family for evenness, balance, exactness, and setting right.

English etymology cannot prove what δικαιώ means in a particular biblical passage or determine Greek usage. It does, however, show why neither “make righteous” nor “declare righteous” should be accepted without further examination. The English word itself has carried causative, demonstrative, judicial, and relational senses.

The controlling question remains:

What kind of rightness is in view, and what does the act of justification say or do about the subject’s relation to it?

To answer that question, we must turn from the history of the English words to the Greek family that stands behind the New Testament language.

The Greek Word Family: Pointing, Placement, and Rightness

The New Testament language of justification belongs to an older Greek family of words. Its principal members include:

- *δίκη (dikē)* — custom, an established way, judgment, settlement, justice
- *δικαίος (dikaios)* — one who is just, correct, or observant of the governing custom or rule
- *δικαιοσύνη (dikaiosynē)* — righteousness or justice
- *δικαιώω (dikaioō)* — to justify or set right
- *δικαίωσις (dikaiōsis)* — a setting right or justification

The family does not begin with an abstract theological definition of moral goodness. The older noun δίκη could describe an established custom or way. Homer could use it in expressions meaning “this is the way of mortals” or “the way of kings.” The same word also came to describe a judgment, a

settlement between disputing parties, the legal process by which such a settlement was reached, and eventually justice in a broader sense.⁹

Custom, judgment, settlement, and justice are not unrelated senses. A customary way identifies how things ordinarily proceed. A judgment determines how a disputed matter ought to be settled. A settlement assigns each party his proper place, claim, or due. Justice describes the right ordering accomplished or recognized through that process.

The deeper etymology is suggestive. δίκη is commonly connected with the Indo-European root *deik-*, meaning “to point out,” “show,” “indicate,” or “direct.”¹⁰ This does not prove that δίκη originally meant a straight line, nor does it allow us to read a spatial metaphor into every later occurrence. It does, however, place the word-family within a conceptual world of indication and direction: a way pointed out, a claim marked, a boundary identified, or a judgment authoritatively pronounced.

Some scholars have proposed that the earliest organizing ideas included a **mark** or **boundary mark**. On that reconstruction, the development is concrete and intelligible. A mark identifies what belongs where. A boundary establishes the rightful extent of a claim. A dispute is settled when the proper line is determined. A judgment declares where the parties stand in relation to that line.

The exact historical development remains debated. Some scholars give priority to the sense of an established “way” or custom; others emphasize judgment and dispute settlement; still others explore the ideas of marking and boundary. We need not settle every part of that debate to recognize the common structure. Throughout the family, the question is not merely whether something possesses an isolated quality called rightness. The question is how someone or something stands in relation to an indicated, established, or authoritative order.

From δίκη comes the adjective δίκαιος. In its earlier uses, δίκαιος can describe someone who observes custom or rule, someone well ordered within society, or something just, correct, fair, balanced, or exact.¹¹ The adjective therefore identifies a person or thing by its relation to what governs it. The δίκαιος person or thing stands as the established order or measure requires.

From δίκαιος comes the verb δικαιόω. Greek verbs ending in -όω are often called factitive because they commonly express causing someone or something to be what the underlying noun or adjective names.

⁹LSJ, s.v. “δίκη”; Michael Gagarin, “Dikē in Archaic Greek Thought,” *Classical Philology* 69, no. 3 (1974): 186–197. Gagarin emphasizes settlement and legal process in early usage.

¹⁰Robert S. P. Beekes, *Etymological Dictionary of Greek* (Leiden: Brill, 2010), s.v. “δίκη”; Hjalmar Frisk, *Griechisches etymologisches Wörterbuch*, s.v. “δίκη.” The connection with the Indo-European root *deik- is widely recognized; the precise semantic development remains disputed.

¹¹LSJ, s.v. “δίκαιος,” including uses for observance of custom or rule, an even-going chariot, balanced counterforces, and exact measurements.

That morphological pattern deserves to be taken seriously. It does not, however, settle the meaning of δικαιώω by itself.¹²

Word formation provides a starting expectation, not a complete definition. A derived verb develops through actual use, and “to make X” does not always mean to produce an internal quality. It may mean to place someone in a condition, to treat someone according to a designation, to recognize a person as possessing a status, or to demonstrate that the designation is appropriate.

For δικαιώω, the distinction is especially important. Its attested meanings include holding or deeming something right, claiming something as right, demanding justice, pronouncing judgment, doing justice to someone, vindicating, and treating or pronouncing someone as righteous. The *Liddell-Scott-Jones Greek-English Lexicon* summarizes the verb broadly as “to set right.”¹³

“Set right” must not be reduced prematurely either to moral transformation or to verbal declaration. The expression is broader than both. It identifies a subject in relation to that which determines rightness.

The word therefore describes a relation, not a moral renovation of the subject. Depending upon the context, that relation may be claimed, recognized, demonstrated, vindicated, or authoritatively pronounced. What remains constant is the underlying question:

How does the subject stand in relation to what is right?

A defensible lexical baseline follows:

To justify is to identify a subject as standing in a right relation to the governing standard. The word may describe that relation as claimed, demonstrated, recognized, vindicated, or authoritatively pronounced, but it does not in itself describe the moral transformation of the subject.

The lexical definition leaves a further question unanswered: how does a sinner come to occupy such a position before God? The verb identifies the relation; the gospel must explain its ground.

¹²Evert van Emde Boas et al., *The Cambridge Grammar of Classical Greek* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2019), §23.45. Verbs in -ώω generally have factitive meaning and are commonly formed from adjectives in -ος.

¹³LSJ, s.v. “δικαιώω.” The entry includes holding or deeming right, claiming as right, pronouncing judgment, doing justice, punishing, and pronouncing or treating as righteous; its short definition is “to set right.”

What Justification Says—and What It Does Not Say

If δικαιώ describes a subject's relation to what is right, then the verb cannot be understood in isolation. Whenever someone or something is justified, three questions are present, whether explicitly stated or supplied by the context:

1. **Who or what is being justified?**
2. **In relation to what standard is the subject being identified as right?**
3. **Who is claiming, recognizing, demonstrating, or pronouncing that relation?**

Those questions do not make δικαιώ an exclusively judicial word. They simply follow from its relational character. If justification concerns where a subject stands, we must ask where, in relation to what, and according to whom.

Several New Testament uses make this structure especially clear.

When the people “justified God” in response to John’s preaching (Luke 7:29), they did not transform God. They acknowledged that God was right. They placed themselves in agreement with His judgment and submitted to the baptism John proclaimed.

Paul uses the verb similarly when he quotes David: “That thou mightest be justified in thy sayings, and mightest overcome when thou art judged” (Romans 3:4; cf. Psalm 51:4; 50:6 LXX). God is not transformed by being justified. His truthfulness is vindicated against every human accusation. When God’s words are brought under judgment, He is shown to stand in the right.

Paul’s quotation is not incidental to his argument. Romans 3 moves from God being justified in His words to God demonstrating His righteousness through Christ, “that he might be just, and the justifier of him which believeth in Jesus” (Romans 3:26). The God who justifies sinners must Himself be shown right in doing so. His verdict cannot be a fiat that ignores or overturns the true standard. God justifies in a manner that demonstrates His own righteousness.

The progression is significant:

God is justified in His words → God’s righteousness is demonstrated in Christ → God is both just and the justifier.

When Jesus says, “Wisdom is justified of all her children” (Luke 7:35), wisdom is not changed into something righteous. Its works or results demonstrate that it is right. What wisdom truly is becomes evident through what it produces.

When the lawyer was “willing to justify himself” (Luke 10:29), he did not intend to transform his own character. He attempted to establish or defend the claim that he stood in the right. His question—“And who is my neighbour?”—was an effort to define the standard in a way that preserved his position.

Jesus later told the Pharisees, “Ye are they which justify yourselves before men; but God knoweth your hearts” (Luke 16:15). Their justification was a claim about their standing, made before a particular audience and measured by a particular standard. Men might accept their claim, but God’s judgment exposed its falsity.

The Pharisees could therefore appear aligned before men while remaining misaligned before God. Their public justification was not meaningless; it successfully established a reputation within the human order. But it could not produce true righteousness because the judgment of men did not establish the governing standard.

The same person could be justified according to one asserted order and condemned according to the true one. The word identifies the claimed or recognized relation; the authority and standard determine whether that relation is real.

Taken together, the examples rule out moral transformation as the basic meaning of δικαιώω. God is not morally transformed when He is justified. Wisdom is not inwardly renewed. The lawyer does not change his character by defending himself. The Pharisees do not become righteous by establishing their reputation before men. The verb says something about the subject, but it does not produce a new moral quality within the subject.

They also show why neither “make righteous” nor “declare righteous” is an adequate universal definition. “Make righteous” naturally suggests an inward transformation and cannot explain occurrences in which God, wisdom, or oneself is justified. “Declare righteous” comes closer because it recognizes the verbal or adjudicative character of many uses, but it can sound as though δικαιώω always refers to a formal courtroom verdict.

The broader idea is more stable:

| To justify is to identify a subject as standing in a right relation to the governing standard.

Context determines the manner in which that relation is presented:

- It may be **claimed**.
- It may be **recognized**.
- It may be **demonstrated**.
- It may be **vindicated** against a challenge.
- It may be **authoritatively pronounced**.

None of these actions necessarily changes the subject. They describe, exhibit, defend, or adjudicate the subject's relation to what is right.

When we come to the justification of the sinner, however, the distinction must be preserved. The word *δικαιόω* tells us how the sinner is identified in relation to God's standard. It does not, by itself, tell us what establishes that relation or how the sinner came to occupy that position.

The ground must not be smuggled into the definition.

If God justifies the sinner, His judgment cannot be false. But neither the morphology of the verb nor the act of pronouncement alone explains why the judgment is true. The gospel must provide the reality to which the justifying judgment corresponds.

Justification raises two distinct questions:

What does God say about the sinner's standing?

What has made that judgment true?

The first is the question answered by *δικαιόω*. The second leads us to the sinner's relation to Christ.

What Makes God's Judgment True?

Scripture presents an apparent difficulty. Proverbs declares:

"He that justifieth the wicked, and he that condemneth the just, even they both are abomination to the LORD" (Proverbs 17:15).

A judgment is unjust when it identifies the wicked as standing in the right or the righteous as standing in the wrong. Such a verdict contradicts the true relation of the subject to the governing standard.

Yet Paul describes God as the One "that justifieth the ungodly" (Romans 4:5).

God condemns a judgment that identifies the wicked as standing in the right, but God Himself justifies the ungodly. How can He do so without rendering the kind of false judgment He calls an abomination?

Before answering, we must understand what *ungodly* means. The Greek word is *ἀσεβής* (*asebēs*), from the word-family of *σέβομαι*, meaning to feel awe, revere, or worship. Ungodliness is therefore not merely an extreme degree of immoral behavior. It is the absence of the reverence and acknowledgment properly owed to God.¹⁴

¹⁴LSJ, s.v. "σέβομαι"; Frederick William Danker, ed., *A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament and Other Early Christian Literature*, 3rd ed. (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2000), s.v. "ἀσεβής." BDAG defines *ἀσεβής* in relation to violating norms for a proper relation to deity.

Ungodliness need not look like open hostility. A man may live in another's house, eat his food, use his furniture, and carefully obey the household rules while scarcely acknowledging the one who owns the house and provides everything in it. His conduct may be correct while his relation remains wrong. He lives as though the rightful master of the house were not there.¹⁵

The ungodly person may likewise imitate much of God's moral order. He may live responsibly, honor his obligations, and appear respectable. His defining problem is not necessarily that he rejects every divine command. It is that he receives life from God while organizing that life without proper reference to God. He may not be openly hostile; indifference is sufficient. He withholds from the rightful Lord the reverence, gratitude, trust, and submission that are His due.

Romans 4:5 does not say that God declares this God-neglect to be righteous. Paul describes the person who is justified in two ways. He is the "ungodly" person, but he is also the one who now "believeth on him that justifieth the ungodly."

Paul's two descriptions must be held together. *Ungodly* identifies the relation from which the sinner comes: life without proper reference to God. *Believing upon God* identifies his present reliance: he has ceased attempting to establish his standing through works and has entrusted himself to God.

Faith answers ungodliness at precisely its relational center. Ungodliness lives without proper reference to God; faith turns toward God in trusting reliance. God does not justify ungodliness. He justifies the ungodly person who believes upon Him.

Faith has not thereby perfected the sinner's moral character; that is not the issue being addressed. The decisive change is relational. The person who lived without proper reference to God has now entrusted himself to God.

Yet faith itself must not be treated as a substitute righteousness or meritorious accomplishment. The question remains: what actual relation makes God's judgment of the believing sinner true?

The answer cannot be naked fiat. If God merely pronounced an ungodly person righteous while leaving his actual relation to God unchanged, the verdict would call misalignment alignment. Divine authority does not make a contradiction true. God's judgments are righteous because they correspond perfectly to reality.

Nor can the answer be sanctification. The person God justifies has not yet become morally perfect. If complete transformation were required before justification could be true, no sinner could be justified during this life.

¹⁵Adapted from James J. Burke, "Ungodliness: It's Not As Bad As You Think," October 15, 2014, pastorjburke.wordpress.com/2014/10/15/ungodliness-its-not-as-bad-as-you-think/.

Something else must account for the verdict. The sinner must possess a real right relation to God that does not depend upon either personal moral perfection or an unsupported declaration. Paul locates that relation **in Christ**, describing his own desired standing in these words:

“And be found in him, not having mine own righteousness, which is of the law, but that which is through the faith of Christ” (Philippians 3:9).

Paul does not merely seek a favorable evaluation of the position he already occupies. He seeks to be *found in Christ*. The righteousness by which he stands is not an independent righteousness established through his own conformity to the law. His standing is determined by where he is found.

He uses the same structure elsewhere:

“But of him are ye in Christ Jesus, who of God is made unto us wisdom, and righteousness, and sanctification, and redemption” (1 Corinthians 1:30).

Christ does not merely donate a detachable quantity called righteousness. He Himself “is made unto us” righteousness, and He is righteousness to those who are **in Christ Jesus**.

The phrase recurs in 2 Corinthians:

“For he hath made him to be sin for us, who knew no sin; that we might be made the righteousness of God in him” (2 Corinthians 5:21).

The decisive words are again **in him**. The sinner’s right standing is not produced by treating Christ’s righteousness as an abstract commodity and transferring it from one account to another. The sinner stands right because he has been placed in the Righteous One.

Union effects an actual relational change, but it is not sanctification. The sinner has not already become morally identical to Christ. He no longer stands before God as an isolated individual beneath a rebel authority; he now stands in Christ, and Christ’s relation to the Father determines his position.

The difference may be stated simply:

- **Sanctification changes the believer’s character and conduct.**
- **Union changes the relation in which the believer stands.**
- **Justification identifies that relation as right.**

Union, justification, and sanctification are distinguishable realities, although they belong to the same saving encounter. Union names the sinner’s incorporation into Christ. Justification names the rightness of the position established in that union. Sanctification describes the transformation of life that follows from belonging to Christ.

Keeping them distinct prevents us from treating Christ's righteousness as either a legal fiction or a transferable substance. His righteousness remains His own, but those who are in Him stand where He stands. What belongs to the Head determines the standing of those incorporated into Him.

The relationship is representative, but it is more than external representation. Christ does not merely act at a distance for people who remain outside Him. They are joined to Him. His history becomes determinative of theirs: His death is counted as their death, His risen life becomes their life, and His standing before the Father becomes their standing.

Paul can thus say both that God justifies the ungodly and that God remains just in doing so. God does not pronounce the rebel order righteous. He does not pretend that self-righteousness corresponds to His standard. He justifies the person who comes as ungodly and believes upon Him.

Through faith, the sinner is found in Christ. He no longer stands before God in the independent position from which he came. God's justifying judgment corresponds to his actual relation:

| The sinner stands right before God because he stands in the Righteous One.

Imputation belongs here as the language of true accounting. If it means that God arbitrarily attributes Christ's righteousness to someone who remains unrelated to Christ, it reduces justification to fiat. But if imputation describes God's true accounting of the person who has been incorporated into Christ, it names the consequence of union rather than a substitute for it. God counts the believer's standing as Christ's standing because the believer is actually in Christ.

The gospel resolves the apparent difficulty between Proverbs 17:15 and Romans 4:5. Proverbs condemns a judgment that falsely identifies the wicked as right. Romans describes God justifying the ungodly person who believes upon Him and is found in Christ.

God remains "just, and the justifier of him which believeth in Jesus" (Romans 3:26), because His justifying judgment does not oppose reality. It declares the rightness of the sinner's actual relation to Christ.

A Baseline Definition of Justification

We can now state the lexical conclusion without forcing every occurrence of δικαιώω into the same English expression:

| To justify is to identify a subject as standing in a right relation to the governing standard.

That relation may be claimed, recognized, demonstrated, vindicated, or authoritatively pronounced. Context determines which of these actions is present. The common structure is the subject's position relative to what governs the judgment of rightness; justification is therefore spatial and relational at its core.

Spatial language answers the question, **Where does the subject stand?**

Relational language answers the question, **In relation to what or whom does the subject stand there?**

The forensic use of justification fits naturally within this structure. A court identifies where a person stands in relation to the law, the evidence, and the claims under judgment. The verdict may acquit, condemn, vindicate, or establish a legal standing. Forensic justification is therefore genuinely relational and spatial.

But the forensic setting does not exhaust the word. God may be justified in His words. Wisdom may be justified by her children. A person may attempt to justify himself before others. In each case, the subject is identified as standing—or claiming to stand—in the right, even where no formal courtroom is present.

“Declare righteous” expresses one important use of δικαιώω, but it is too narrow to serve as the word's universal definition. It describes one manner in which a right relation may be authoritatively pronounced.

“Make righteous” is also inadequate if it means morally transforming the subject. There is, however, a relational sense in which someone may be *made right*: he may be placed into the position in which he ought to stand. Such a change is real without being a transformation of moral character. It is a change of relation, allegiance, and position.

The distinction can now be stated precisely:

- **Union establishes the sinner's position in Christ.**
- **Justification identifies that position as right.**
- **Sanctification progressively brings the believer's character and conduct into correspondence with the position he already occupies.**

Justification is neither an inward moral renovation nor an unsupported verdict. It does not transform the sinner's character, but neither does it ask God to call an unchanged relation righteous. God's judgment is true because the believing sinner has been placed in Christ.

The righteousness in which the sinner stands is not an independent moral possession. It is not a substance detached from Christ and transferred into the sinner. Christ Himself is the Righteous One, and the sinner stands right because he is found in Him.

Faith, accordingly, must not be treated as a substitute righteousness. It does not become a meritorious quality that satisfies the standard. Faith is the sinner's trusting reliance upon God—the relational reversal of ungodliness. The sinner ceases attempting to establish his own standing and entrusts himself to the One who justifies; God's justifying judgment then corresponds to the sinner's actual position in Christ.

We may now distinguish three related statements:

The lexical baseline: To justify is to identify a subject as standing in a right relation to the governing standard.

The theological ground: The believing sinner stands right before God because he stands in Christ, the Righteous One.

The doctrine of justification: Justification is God's true and authoritative judgment that the sinner who believes upon Him stands in right relation to God because he is found in Christ.

Taken together, these statements preserve the legitimate insights of the traditional language while correcting its possible distortions:

- Justification is **forensic** because God renders an authoritative judgment concerning the sinner's standing.
- It is **not a legal fiction** because the judgment corresponds to the sinner's real relation to Christ.
- It is **not sanctification** because it does not describe the transformation of the sinner's moral character.
- It is **received by faith** because faith entrusts the sinner to God rather than establishing an independent righteousness.
- It is **grounded in Christ** because Christ's standing before the Father determines the standing of those who are in Him.

The expression “brought into line” gathers these truths into an accessible picture. The line is not merely a list of moral requirements. It is the true order proceeding from the rightful authority of God and embodied in the Righteous One.

The sinner cannot bring himself into line by copying the outward form of that order. A rebel may imitate the King's laws while remaining under a rival authority. Nor can God bring the sinner into line merely by calling misalignment alignment. The sinner must instead be found in Christ.

There, and only there, the sinner stands in proper relation to the rightful Lord and His order. God's justifying judgment does not invent that relation. It identifies the sinner according to the position he truly occupies:

Right with God because he stands in the Righteous One.

We have not attempted to interpret every New Testament occurrence of δικαιώω. That work requires careful attention to each passage, its grammar, its argument, and the standard operating within it. The purpose here has been more foundational: to establish a lexically responsible understanding of the word before bringing that understanding to the individual texts.

The passages must still speak for themselves. But we can now approach them with a better question than whether δικαιώω always means “declare righteous” or “make righteous”:

What relation is being described, what establishes the governing standard, and where does the subject stand in relation to it?